





VINCENT

Error 404: Life in a Secret Chinese Nuclear City That Was Never on the Map

A memoir of growing up in China's classified atomic bomb base in the Gobi Desert.



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DEC 28, 2025

Years later, when I saw “404 Not Found” on a computer screen, I was confused. How did the internet know my hometown was a secret?

404 is a classified code for a nuclear industrial base. In 1958, elite scientists and laborers from across China gathered in the Gobi Desert to build a city from scratch, with a single goal: to build the **atomic bomb**. I grew up in this small city.



People in 404 Celebrating Chinese New Year

1. The City That Didn't Exist

In my childhood bedroom, a glossy map of China hung on the wall. I used to believe it showed our factory area, the 404. On that map, I saw Shanxi, where my father was from, and the Northeast, my mother's home. Our neighbors had roots in Shandong and Shanghai.

At age three, I would trace the map with my small finger, trying to find 404's Central Park or the Workers' Club. I couldn't find them. I assumed the large blue patch was my home, and the green patch belonged to my friend upstairs.

In reality, Factory 404 was not marked on any map.

Years later, when I first used the internet and saw “404: Page Not Found” pop up on a screen, I was genuinely perplexed. How did the computer know that “404” couldn't be found ?

Located west of the Yumen Pass, 404 was a secret society hidden in the Gobi Desert. In 1958, the state mobilized thousands to build this oasis





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